Canva Sublimation Card

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The white-ink rule, the blank, the sizes. Verified 5 October 2026.

THE ONE THAT RUINS DESIGNS

There is no white ink. White is a WINDOW onto the blank.

"Dye sublimation requires light-colored materials because there's no white ink in the standard process. White areas are inherent to the product itself."

Printify. Sawgrass say the same of their VersiFlex ink: it does not print with white.

In Canva white is a colour you pick. At the press it is the absence of ink, so:

+ White text on a DARK SHAPE works - the shape is ink, the letters are the blank
- White text on nothing is invisible. Blank on blank
- A white drop shadow, outline or glow does nothing at all
- Off-white, cream and the palest grey ARE ink - they do print

The ten-second test: drop a mid-tone rectangle behind your design and see what survives.

THE BLANK

"Dye-sublimation printing requires polyester fabrics or polymer-coated surfaces." (Epson.) Not a preference - the dye bonds with polyester. On cotton it sits on the surface, looks acceptable for about one wash, and then it is gone.

+ Polyester fabric, or a polymer-coated hard good (mug, tumbler, slate, metal)
+ LIGHT blanks only - on a dark blank the ink is translucent and disappears
- Cotton, or an uncoated mug from a supermarket: takes nothing at all

THE SIZE

`inches x 300 = pixels`

9 x 3.5 in mug wrap	**`2700 x 1050 px`**
10 x 12 in shirt area	**`3000 x 3600 px`**

Your blank supplier publishes a template. THAT is the number that counts - suppliers differ.

Canva: Custom size, switch units to pixels, type it in. Never design small and scale up.

THE EXPORT - AND THE MYTH

"Export transparent or you get a white box" is a PRINT ON DEMAND rule, where a provider lays white ink onto a dark shirt. Your sublimation printer has no white ink, so a white background and a transparent one do the same thing. Export transparent anyway - it is the only way YOU can see the windows.

Share > Download > PNG > Transparent background ON. Tick 2x size if offered.

Transparent background is Canva Pro, Teams, Business, Education and Nonprofits only.

Mirror ONCE. Most printer software mirrors for you - do both and it is not mirrored.

Canva is RGB and converts automatically. Press a colour swatch sheet once and keep it.

SEVEN CHECKS BEFORE YOU PRESS

* **The background is deleted, not white**
* **Everything that must be visible is INK, not white**
* **You looked at it on a mid-tone background and it still reads**
* The PNG is transparent, and in the thousands of pixels
* The blank is polyester or polymer coated - and light
* You mirrored exactly once. Printer software OR Canva, not both
* Every element came from a Canva search filtered to Free

The first three are all the same thing, which tells you how often it is the thing that goes wrong.

Sources: Epson; Printify; Sawgrass; Canva Help Centre; Canva Content Licence Agreement.